

BUILD BY MAIL STARTER KIT



CaribStream.io

Build By Mail Starter Kit

How to Launch a Snail Mail Subscription Business.

- 1 Find Your Niche**
The niche you pick determines everything — your community, your content, your staying power
- 2 Master the One-Ounce Rule**
The single most important technical rule. Violate it and your margins disappear permanently
- 3 Design Your First Envelope**
Your envelope is your product. It needs to feel like something worth waiting for every month
- 4 Price Your Subscription**
The \$9–\$11 framework, annual pricing strategy, and what never to do with your price
- 5 Set Up Your Payment System**
Google Form plus Stripe from day one — the simplest setup that actually works
- 6 Find Your First 50 Subscribers**
Organic content, three post types, and the roadmap from zero to your first paying audience

INCOME BENCHMARKS

50 subscribers @ \$10/month: \$350/month profit · 500 subscribers: \$3,500/month · 1,000 subscribers: \$7,000/month · 2,000 subscribers: \$14,000/month. These numbers assume a \$3 cost per envelope. Your niche and consistency determine your actual results.

Find Your Niche

The niche you pick determines everything. Your community, your content, your staying power.

Not every interest makes a great subscription niche. The snail mail subscriptions that survive and scale are built around three qualities: community identity, content depth, and underserved demand. Get all three right and you have a business. Miss one and you have a hobby.

Three Qualities of a Winning Niche

1

Community Identity

The strongest niches are built around who people are — not just what they like. Caribbean diaspora communities are not just interested in history — they are proud of their roots. When a niche is tied to identity, subscribers stay longer and refer more. They share your product because it reflects something about who they are.

2

Content Depth

You need compelling new content every single month — for years. Before you commit to a niche, brainstorm 24 months of content ideas right now. If you run dry before month 12, that niche may be too narrow. Open a notes app and write 24 content ideas before moving to Chapter 2.

3

Underserved Demand

The most profitable niches are not the most obvious ones. They are the ones that have a real audience but no one has built the right product for yet. The gap is where the opportunity lives. Your Caribbean community is full of gaps that generic subscription boxes have never addressed.

Proven Niche Categories

Children & Culture

Community & Identity

Interests & Hobbies

Caribbean children's stories · STEM for girls Black family legacy Natural hair community	Caribbean diaspora art HBCU alumni culture Black fatherhood Gospel and faith	Classic car enthusiasts Urban gardeners True crime readers Amateur astronomers
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THE NICHE TEST

Run your niche through four questions before locking it in. Can I describe my ideal subscriber in one sentence? Can I name five places online where this community already gathers? Can I write 24 months of content ideas right now? Is there a gap — meaning no one is doing this well for this audience by mail? Four yes answers. Then lock it in and move to Chapter 2.

CARIBBEAN EARNER PRINCIPLE

Carnival did not start as a global event. It started as a specific community expression for a specific people in a specific place. Your niche starts the same way — narrow, specific, and rooted in real community identity. That specificity is not a limitation. It is the moat.

Master the One-Ounce Rule

The single most important technical rule in this business. Violate it and your margins disappear.

USPS charges one Forever Stamp for standard mail up to one ounce. The moment your envelope exceeds one ounce, postage jumps significantly. On a \$10 subscription this is the difference between a profitable business and a money-losing one. At 500 subscribers the gap is over \$1,000 per month. At 2,000 subscribers it is more than \$4,000. Buy a kitchen scale before you design a single piece of content.

Item	Weight	Cost
Envelope	0.16 oz	\$0.08 – \$0.12
One Forever Stamp	—	\$0.68
Letter / story page (20lb paper)	0.17 oz	\$0.08 – \$0.15
Art print or postcard	0.22 oz	\$0.15 – \$0.25
Stickers (2–3 pieces)	0.07 oz	\$0.10 – \$0.20
Paper extra (bookmark, activity)	0.12 oz	\$0.08 – \$0.15
Address label	0.04 oz	\$0.03 – \$0.05
TARGET TOTAL	~0.78 oz	~\$3.00 with buffer

Content That Works

One story page on 20lb paper · One art print on card stock · Two to three stickers · One paper extra such as a bookmark or activity sheet. All of these fit under one ounce.

Content That Breaks Your Budget

Any item with thickness or rigidity · Coins or metal objects · Multiple full sheets of card stock · Cardboard inserts of any kind · Anything that cannot be weighed before you scale.

St. Kitts built its entire financial sector on one founding principle — protect the structure before you grow it. The one-ounce rule is your structure. Every content decision you make runs through this number first. Know it before you design anything. It saves the business.

Design Your First Envelope

Your envelope is your product. It needs to feel like something worth waiting for.

Every Caribbean Earner subscription envelope has four core elements. Each one earns its weight — literally. Design all four before you take a single subscriber. The subscriber who opens your envelope for the first time decides in ten seconds whether they are staying or cancelling. Make those ten seconds count.

The Four Elements of a Great Subscription Envelope

1

The Letter

This is the heart of your subscription. The reason someone stays subscribed month after month. Write it like a journal entry — personal, real, human. For a children's storytelling subscription, the letter is the story itself, written as if the character is speaking directly to the child. For a culture subscription, it is a personal note connecting the reader to their roots. The letter is never corporate. It is always from one person to another.

2

The Art or Visual

Every envelope has something beautiful to look at. A postcard. An illustration. An art print. Something the subscriber keeps or puts on a wall. For Caribbean subscriptions this is especially powerful — an original drawing of a historic Caribbean landmark, a vibrant island market scene, a piece that makes the subscriber proud of what arrived in their mailbox. Canva Pro at \$13/month lets you design professional art prints without a design background.

3

The Stickers

Stickers are lightweight, inexpensive, and beloved. They give subscribers something interactive — something to use, gift, or collect. They also function as subtle community marketing when subscribers put them on water bottles, laptops, and notebooks. Order custom stickers in bulk from Sticker Mule or Canva Print. At 500 units the cost drops dramatically.

4

The Surprise

One rotating element that changes every month and delights subscribers. A mini activity. A collage card. A bookmark. A craft sheet. Something unexpected that adds value without adding weight. This is the element subscribers mention most when they tell friends about your subscription. Make it count — and weigh it before it goes in.

DESIGNING FOR SCALABILITY

Create templates in Canva that you update monthly — don't redesign from scratch each month. Use the same envelope size every month. Print in batches using Canva Print or a local printer. Build a production checklist from day one so packing day is systematic. Your first month you design everything yourself. By month six you are sending 500 envelopes. Design with that version of yourself in mind from the start.

CARIBBEAN EARNER PRINCIPLE

Tobago has one of the oldest protected coral reefs in the Western Hemisphere — preserved not by accident but by people who understood what they had. Your envelope is what your subscribers have. Protect the quality of it every single month. That quality is why they stay.

Price Your Subscription

The \$9–\$11 sweet spot, annual pricing strategy, and what to never do with your price.

Pricing is where most beginners undervalue their work. Price too low and you train subscribers to expect cheapness. Price at value and you attract subscribers who are serious. Your price needs to accomplish three things: cover your costs, reflect your value, and convert your audience.

Pricing Tier	Range	Notes
Cost per envelope	~\$3.00	Your floor — never price below 2x this
Minimum viable price	\$6.00	Covers costs — no growth margin
Recommended entry price	\$9.00 – \$11.00	Sweet spot for most niches
Premium (high-value niches)	\$14.00 – \$18.00	Art, culture, collector editions

Annual vs Monthly Pricing

Once you have at least 50 subscribers, introduce an annual option. Offer it at two months free — so a \$10/month subscription becomes \$100/year. You collect \$100 upfront instead of \$10 monthly. That cash flow funds your content creation and print runs for the entire year. Annual subscribers churn at a fraction of the rate of monthly subscribers. Do not launch with annual pricing. Get 50 monthly subscribers first. Prove the product. Then introduce annual as an upgrade.

What to never do with pricing

Never discount more than 20% for any promotion. Never offer a free trial — it attracts subscribers who were never going to pay. Never apologize for your price in your marketing copy. Never lower your price because someone asks you to — offer a pause instead.

The right subscriber for your price

People who see your price and still sign up are your most loyal customers. They made a considered decision. They value what you are building. Those subscribers refer others, leave reviews, and stay for years. Price for them.

The Cayman Islands built a global financial industry on one principle — serve clients who understand value and are willing to pay for it. The subscribers who pay attention to your price and still sign up are your Cayman clients. Price accordingly and never apologize for it.

Set Up Your Payment System

Collect subscriber information and charge them automatically. No tech background required.

You do not need a website to start. You need two things: a way to collect subscriber information and a way to charge them automatically. The simplest setup that actually works is Google Form plus Stripe. It costs nothing to create, handles recurring billing, and gets you to your first subscriber today.

Day One Setup — Google Form + Stripe

1

Google Form — Subscriber Information

Go to forms.google.com and create a new form. Add fields: Full Name, Mailing Address, Email Address. Add a description at the top that clearly states the price and what they are signing up for. Be explicit about the price from the very first line. If subscribers do not know it costs money before they fill it out, you will attract low-intent signups who never convert. State the price clearly. Always.

2

Stripe — Recurring Payments

Create a free account at stripe.com. Set up a recurring payment link for your monthly price. Include the Stripe payment link in your Google Form confirmation message. Subscribers complete the form, then complete payment — two steps, done. Stripe charges approximately 2.9% plus 30 cents per transaction. On a \$10 subscription that is about 59 cents — well within your margin.

3

Subscriber List — Your Most Valuable Asset

From day one, maintain a spreadsheet of every subscriber: name, mailing address, email, signup date, and subscription status. Use Google Sheets — it is free and accessible from anywhere. Export your mailing list as a CSV before every ship day. Back it up monthly. Losing your subscriber list is a business-ending event. Your subscriber list is your business. Treat it like the asset it is.

SCALING UP — 100+ SUBSCRIBERS

Once you hit 100–200 subscribers the Google Form plus Stripe setup becomes harder to manage. Move to a dedicated creator platform. Stan Store combines your link-in-bio page, digital product sales, and subscription management in one dashboard for \$29/month. Beacons is an alternative with a free tier.

CARIBBEAN EARNER PRINCIPLE

Barbados built the Caribbean's most reliable infrastructure through disciplined, methodical investment in foundations. Your payment system is your foundation. Get it right from day one — simple, clean, and working — and every subscriber you add builds directly on top of it.

Find Your First 50 Subscribers

Your first 50 subscribers validate the idea, fund the first print run, and become your ambassadors.

You do not need paid ads to get your first 50 subscribers. You need consistent, authentic content on TikTok, YouTube Shorts, or Instagram Reels. The content that works is not polished advertising. It is documentation. You show people what you are building, why you are building it, and what makes it different. The audience that finds you through that content is your best audience.

Three Content Types That Work

1	The Sell — Once Per Week A direct, no-nonsense explanation of what your subscription is, who it is for, and how to sign up. Show the product. State the price. Give a clear call to action. Keep it under 30 seconds. No soft sells. No vague language. Tell them exactly what to do next.
2	The Educate — Twice Per Week Teach something real about your niche or your business model. Show the one-ounce math. Explain why your niche is underserved. Give value with no strings attached. People who learn something from you trust you. People who trust you buy from you.
3	The Document — Ongoing Show the behind-the-scenes. Designing your first envelope. Packing day. Your first subscriber notification. A mistake you made and what you learned. Authenticity is the most powerful marketing tool available to a small business right now. Raw, honest documentation of a real build stands out immediately.

Your First 50 Subscriber Roadmap

Week	Action
Week 1	Post your first content the same week you set up your payment link — no waiting for perfection
Week 1	Tell 10 people you know personally and ask them to share your content

Weeks 1–3	Post consistently for three weeks before evaluating what is working
Ongoing	Engage with every comment — especially in the first 30 days
Launch	Offer a launch month discount to the first 25 subscribers only — creates urgency
Milestones	Share every milestone publicly: first subscriber, first 10, first 25, first 50

CARIBBEAN EARNER SERIES — ALSO AVAILABLE

Google Visibility Blueprint

\$69 · Help local businesses get found on Google · Monthly retainer income

AI Business Blueprint

\$69 · Charge \$500–\$2,000/month to set up and manage AI for local businesses

caribstream.io/earner

CARIBBEAN EARNER PRINCIPLE

Trinidad's Carnival built its global reputation one performance at a time — consistent, specific, and real — long before social media existed. Your content builds your subscriber base the same way. One post at a time. Consistent. Specific. Yours.

YOUR FIRST 30-DAY ACTION PLAN

Week 1 — Choose your niche and build your system

Complete the niche test. Write 24 months of content ideas. Buy a kitchen scale. Set up Google Form and Stripe. Design your first envelope prototype.

Week 2 — Post your first content

Film and post your first three videos — one sell, one educate, one document. Share your payment link. Tell 10 people in your network personally.

Weeks 3–4 — Convert subscribers and ship

Post consistently. Engage every comment. Convert your first subscriber. Finalize your print files. Pack your first envelopes. Ship on a fixed date. You are now a subscription business owner.

REAL SKILLS. REAL INCOME. NO HYPE.

Caribbean adults abroad. Building wealth. Keeping roots.

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